

GovCon BD Upskilling Program

Proposal Support Basics

Module 4.1 | Domain D4 (13%)

DURATION

2-3 hours

FORMAT

Live Instructor-Led

GovConGiants

30-Day Foundation Program

Module 4.1: Proposal Support Basics

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, learners will be able to:

1. **Explain** the proposal development process and key roles involved
2. **Read** and interpret RFP instructions and evaluation criteria
3. **Build** a compliance matrix mapping RFP requirements to proposal sections
4. **Identify** common proposal volumes and their purposes
5. **Contribute** effectively to proposal efforts in a supporting role

Required Reading/Viewing

Official Government Resources (Free)

1. **SAM.gov** - Sample Solicitation Documents
 - URL: <https://sam.gov/content/opportunities>
 - Focus: Download and review actual RFPs to understand structure
2. **FAR Part 15** - Contracting by Negotiation
 - URL: <https://www.acquisition.gov/far/part-15>
 - Focus: Section 15.3 (Source Selection) and 15.4 (Proposal Preparation)
3. **GSA Schedules Solicitation** - Example of Proposal Requirements
 - URL: <https://www.gsa.gov/buy-through-us/purchasing-programs/gsa-multiple-award-schedule>
 - Focus: Understanding proposal structure

Action Plan Journal References

- **Find Industry Specific Bids/Pre-solicitation:** page 135
- **Identify Local Contract Award Winners and Solicit:** pages 130-131

Lesson Content

1. The Proposal Development Process

Proposal development is a structured process that transforms capture intelligence and solution designs into a compliant, compelling response.

Typical Proposal Timeline (30-day example):

Pre-Proposal	Before RFP	Capture activities, solution development, draft content
RFP Analysis	1-3	Compliance matrix, kickoff, assignments
Writing	4-15	Draft content, graphics, data calls
Pink Team Review	16-18	First major review (outline/early draft)
Revisions	19-22	Incorporate feedback, refine
Red Team Review	23-25	Near-final review
Final Revisions	26-28	Final polishing
Production	29-30	Format, page check, submit

Key Principle

The better the capture work, the easier the proposal. Most “proposal problems” are really “capture problems.”

2. Proposal Team Roles

Capture Manager	Leads pre-proposal; transitions to proposal; owns win strategy
Proposal Manager	Runs the proposal process; schedule, compliance, production
Volume Leads	Own specific volumes (technical, management, past performance)
Writers/Contributors	Draft proposal content
Subject Matter Experts	Provide technical accuracy and detail

Reviewers	Evaluate drafts against RFP and win strategy
Pricing Lead	Develops cost/price volume
Contracts	Reviews terms, reps/certs, ensures compliance
Graphics	Creates visuals, charts, diagrams
Production	Final formatting, assembly, submission

Your Role: Even if you're not a dedicated proposal professional, you may be asked to:

- Provide technical input or data
- Review sections for accuracy
- Gather past performance information
- Support data calls (staffing, resumes, etc.)
- Help with final production

3. Understanding RFP Structure

A typical RFP contains several key sections:

Section A	Solicitation form (SF 33 or SF 1449)	Basic contract info
Section B	Supplies/Services and Prices	What you're bidding on
Section C	Statement of Work (SOW) or PWS	Technical requirements
Section L	Instructions to Offerors	How to prepare your proposal
Section M	Evaluation Factors	How you'll be scored
Attachments	CLINs, data requirements, templates	Supporting documents

Critical Sections for Proposal Compliance:

- **Section L:** Tells you exactly what to submit, format requirements, page limits
- **Section M:** Tells you how you'll be evaluated and what matters most

Example Section L Instructions

"The Technical Volume shall not exceed 50 pages. Use 12-point Times New Roman font with 1-inch margins. Include a staffing plan, technical approach, and transition plan..."

4. Building a Compliance Matrix

The **compliance matrix** is the backbone of proposal development. It maps every RFP requirement to your proposal response.

Why It Matters:

- Ensures nothing is missed
- Assigns responsibility for each requirement
- Tracks compliance status
- Guides evaluators to your responses

Basic Compliance Matrix Structure:

L.4.1	Provide staffing plan	Vol 1, Sec 3.1	12-15	Yes	J. Smith
L.4.2	Include org chart	Vol 1, Sec 3.2	16	Yes	J. Smith
C.3.1	24x7 support capability	Vol 1, Sec 2.3	8-9	Yes	T. Jones
M.1	Technical Approach	Vol 1, Sec 2	5-20	Yes	Lead

Building a Compliance Matrix Step-by-Step:

1. **Read Section L completely** - Extract every instruction
2. **Read Section M completely** - Note all evaluation factors
3. **Read Section C (SOW/PWS)** - Identify all requirements
4. **Create requirement rows** - One row per requirement
5. **Map to proposal sections** - Where will you address each?
6. **Assign owners** - Who's responsible?
7. **Track completion** - Update as proposal develops

5. Common Proposal Volumes

Most proposals have separate volumes for different content:

Volume I: Technical	Technical approach, solution, staffing, management	How you'll do the work
Volume II: Past Performance	Relevant experience, references	Proof you can do it

Volume III: Price/Cost	Pricing, cost breakdown	What it will cost
Volume IV: Administrative	Reps/certs, subcontracting plan	Compliance documents

Technical Volume Key Sections:

- Technical Approach: How you'll accomplish the work
- Management Approach: How you'll manage the contract
- Staffing Plan: Who will do the work
- Transition Plan: How you'll start up smoothly
- Quality Control: How you'll ensure quality

Past Performance Key Elements:

- Contract name and number
- Customer contact information
- Relevance to current requirement
- Contract value and period
- Description of work performed
- Performance outcomes/metrics

6. Evaluation Factors and What Evaluators Look For

Understanding evaluation factors helps you prioritize your proposal content.

Typical Evaluation Factor Structure:

Technical/Management	40-50%	Solution quality, understanding, approach
Past Performance	25-35%	Relevant experience, performance quality
Price	15-30%	Cost realism, competitiveness
Small Business	5-15%	Subcontracting plan (large business only)

Evaluation Ratings (Common Scale):

Outstanding	Exceptional; significantly exceeds requirements
Good	Meets and occasionally exceeds requirements
Acceptable	Meets minimum requirements

Marginal	Fails to meet some requirements
Unacceptable	Fails to meet requirements; not awardable

What Makes a Proposal “Outstanding”:

- Clear compliance with all requirements
- Specific, relevant past performance
- Concrete proof points, not generalities
- Thoughtful understanding of customer’s challenges
- Innovative approaches that add value
- Strong, relevant team

7. Supporting Proposals: Common Tasks

When asked to support a proposal, you may be assigned to:

Data Calls: Provide specific information

- Resume updates
- Past performance narratives
- Technical specifications
- Pricing inputs
- Certifications/licenses

Content Review: Check sections for accuracy

- Technical accuracy
- Company information correctness
- Consistency with company capabilities
- Grammar and clarity

Research Support:

- Incumbent research (SAM.gov Contract Data)
- Customer intel gathering
- Competitive analysis support
- Regulation/policy research

Production Support:

- Formatting documents
- Checking page counts
- Assembling final package
- Quality control checks

8. Proposal Dos and Don’ts

Do:

- Read the RFP carefully before starting
- Follow all instructions exactly (page limits, fonts, format)
- Be specific with examples and proof points
- Address every requirement explicitly
- Use clear, direct language
- Highlight your discriminators and win themes
- Meet all deadlines (internal and external)

Don't:

- Submit generic boilerplate content
- Miss page limits or format requirements
- Make claims you can't prove
- Criticize competitors by name
- Assume evaluators know your company
- Wait until the last minute
- Ignore evaluation criteria weighting

AI Accelerator: Using AI for Proposal Support

AI tools can dramatically accelerate proposal development—from RFP analysis to content drafting.

Prompt 1: Analyze RFP Requirements

Use When: You need to quickly understand what an RFP requires.

Analyze this RFP section and extract all requirements:

[PASTE SECTION L OR SECTION C TEXT]

Provide:

1. Explicit requirements (stated directly)
2. Implicit requirements (implied but not stated)
3. Compliance items (specific deliverables or formats required)
4. Potential ambiguities or questions to ask
5. Any unusual or non-standard requirements

Format as a requirements checklist I can use for compliance tracking.

Prompt 2: Summarize Evaluation Criteria

Use When: You need to understand how the proposal will be scored.

Analyze this Section M (Evaluation Factors):

[PASTE SECTION M TEXT]

Help me understand:

1. What are the evaluation factors and their weights?
2. What does "Outstanding" look like for each factor?
3. What are the discriminating factors (where we can win or lose)?
4. What's the relationship between price and technical?
5. What should we emphasize most in our response?

Create a scoring guide for our proposal team.

Prompt 3: Build Initial Compliance Matrix

Use When: You need to start a compliance matrix quickly.

Create a compliance matrix from this RFP section:

[PASTE SECTION L INSTRUCTIONS]

Format as a table with columns:

- RFP Reference (section number)
- Requirement Description
- Proposed Response Location
- Compliance Status (TBD)
- Assigned Owner (TBD)
- Notes

Include every requirement, including formatting and page limits.

Prompt 4: Draft Past Performance Narrative

Use When: You need to write a past performance citation.

Help me draft a past performance narrative:

Contract Information:

- Contract Name: [NAME]
- Customer: [AGENCY]
- Contract Number: [NUMBER]
- Value: [AMOUNT]
- Period: [DATES]
- Your Role: [PRIME/SUB]

Work Performed:

- [DESCRIBE THE WORK]

Relevance to Current Opportunity:

- Similar scope: [HOW]
- Similar size: [HOW]
- Similar complexity: [HOW]

Results/Outcomes:

- [QUANTIFIED ACHIEVEMENTS]

Draft a past performance narrative that:

1. Clearly shows relevance to the current RFP
2. Emphasizes successful outcomes with metrics
3. Demonstrates our capabilities
4. Fits in [X] words/page limit

Pro Tips for AI-Assisted Proposal Support

Use AI to extract requirements from RFPs	Submit AI-generated content without review
Get AI help outlining proposal sections	Let AI access actual proposal files
Draft past performance narratives with AI	Use AI for pricing or cost volumes
Check compliance with AI assistance	Share proprietary win strategies with AI

Remember

AI accelerates proposal work but doesn't replace expertise. Always have subject matter experts review AI-assisted content, and never submit AI output without thorough human review.

■ Applied Exercise: Build a Compliance Matrix

Scenario: Your company is responding to an RFP. Your manager asks you to build the initial compliance matrix from Section L.

Part 1: Find an RFP

1. Go to SAM.gov
2. Search for a solicitation in your NAICS code (or use "IT services")
3. Download the solicitation documents
4. Locate Section L (Instructions to Offerors)

Part 2: Extract Requirements

Read Section L and list every requirement, including:

- Volume requirements
- Page limits
- Format requirements
- Content requirements
- Submission instructions

Part 3: Build the Compliance Matrix

Use the Work Artifact template to create a compliance matrix with at least 15 requirements.

Time: 45-60 minutes

■ Work Artifact: Compliance Matrix

Header

Your Name: _____

Date: _____

Solicitation Number: _____

Section 1: RFP Overview

Agency	
Contract Type	
Estimated Value	
Set-Aside	
NAICS Code	
Evaluation Approach	

Section 2: Evaluation Factors Summary

	%	
	%	
	%	
	%	

Section 3: Format Requirements

Page Limit (Technical)	
Page Limit (Past Performance)	
Font	
Margins	
Line Spacing	
Submission Method	

Number of Copies	
------------------	--

Section 4: Compliance Matrix

1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					

(Continue for items 11-15)

Section 5: Key Compliance Risks

Knowledge Check (Self-Assessment)

Question 1 (Recall)

What section of an RFP contains the instructions for how to prepare your proposal?

- A) Section A
- B) Section C

C) **Section L**

D) Section M

Correct Answer: C

Question 2 (Application)

The RFP states: “Technical Volume shall not exceed 50 pages using 12-point font.” Your draft is 55 pages. What should you do?

A) Submit it anyway—evaluators will understand

B) Use a smaller font to fit more content

C) **Edit content to meet the 50-page limit exactly**

D) Add an appendix for the extra pages

Correct Answer: C

Question 3 (Recall)

What is the purpose of a compliance matrix?

A) To track project milestones after award

B) **To map every RFP requirement to your proposal response**

C) To calculate your price

D) To evaluate competitors

Correct Answer: B

Question 4 (Application)

The evaluation factors state: “Technical (40%), Past Performance (30%), Price (30%). Technical and Past Performance are significantly more important than Price.” What does this tell you?

A) Price is the most important factor

B) **Focus your strongest effort on Technical and Past Performance**

C) All factors are weighted equally

D) You should submit the lowest price possible

Correct Answer: B

Question 5 (Recall)

What is a “Pink Team” review?

A) Final review before submission

- B) **Early review of proposal outline or initial draft**
- C) Customer review of your proposal
- D) Competitor analysis review

Correct Answer: B

■ Manager Discussion Prompts

1. **Current Context:** “How does our company manage proposals? Is there a proposal team or coordinator I should connect with?”
2. **Application:** “Are there upcoming proposals I could support? What kind of input is typically needed from my role?”
3. **Career Development:** “What proposal skills would be most valuable for me to develop? Are there proposal reviews I could observe?”

■ Completion Criteria

To complete this module:

- ☐ Read all required materials (approximately 20 minutes)
- ☐ Complete the lesson content review (30-45 minutes)
- ☐ Finish the Applied Exercise (download an RFP and build compliance matrix)
- ☐ Submit a Compliance Matrix with at least 15 requirements mapped
- ☐ Review the Knowledge Check questions (self-assessment)
- ☐ Participate in manager discussion (or document self-reflection)

Estimated Total Time: 2-3 hours

■ Additional Resources

Proposal Terminology Glossary

Section L: Instructions to Offerors—how to prepare your proposal

Section M: Evaluation Factors—how you'll be scored

SOW/PWS: Statement of Work / Performance Work Statement—the requirements

Compliance Matrix: Document mapping RFP requirements to proposal sections

Pink Team: Early proposal review (outline/initial draft)

Red Team: Near-final proposal review

Gold Team: Final executive review before submission

BAFO: Best and Final Offer—revised proposal after discussions

Action Plan Journal Activities

After completing this module, use your **Action Plan Journal** to:

1. Use **Find Industry Specific Bids/Pre-solicitation** (page 135) to track RFP sources
2. Review **Identify Local Contract Award Winners and Solicit** (pages 130-131) for past performance research

Journal Reference

The Compliance Matrix you completed is a critical capture/proposal tool. Keep a copy in your working files alongside your Action Plan Journal to reference during future proposal efforts.